

From:

GET TO THE POINT: HOW TO SAY WHAT YOU MEAN AND GET WHAT YOU WANT

by Karen Berg and Andrew Gilman

The Three-Minute Presentation Writing Technique

Somebody once asked Abraham Lincoln how long it took him to prepare a speech. "It takes me about two weeks to write a good twenty-minute speech," he said, "but I can write a *forty*-minute speech in *one* week. And," he added, "I can give a two-hour talk on almost any subject right now." Or, as a correspondent of ours once put it: "If I'd had more time, I'd have written you a shorter letter."

The point? It's hard to be concise.

With our three-minute presentation writing technique, however, we give you a way to cut the job down to size. Once you are proficient with it, you should be able to draft your presentation in three minutes or less, regardless of length. Our technique works whether you make thirty-second, five-minute, or two-hour presentations.

The technique centers on two easy steps:

1. Stating your conclusion
2. Listing your arguments

These elements comprise the core of your presentation. Almost the entire structure flows from them. A third element is often necessary to complete the scheme, and that has to do with the "lead" we just mentioned. We'll discuss that later.